IT was 'Aww' at first sight. In 2017, when natural history and social documentary photographer and filmmaker Kartiki Gonsalves was driving to Bengaluru, she chanced upon an adorable sight on her way, at the Mudumalai Tiger Reserve in Tamil Nadu—a three-month-old elephant calf, Raghu, being taken to the river for a bath by his human caretaker, Bomman. "I instantly saw this beautiful bond between the two where he [Bomman] was literally everything to Raghu," she says. The encounter marked the beginning of a five-year cinematic journey, during which Gonsalves and her crew followed the displaced calves, Raghu and Ammu, and their adopted parents, Bomman and Bellie, across different seasons. That journey culminates in Los Angeles, where Gonsalves's film, *The Elephant Whisperers* (streaming on Netflix), is in contention for the best documentary short Oscar.

For Gonsalves, devoting time to observe the unlikely family was essential for her creative process. "When it comes to nature, it is all unpredictable," she says. "You have to be patient." It didn't just allow Gonsalves to befriend them but also made the story more wholesome as she got to illustrate the problem of young elephants who get separated from their herd and have to be domesticated, after all efforts at reunification fail. *The Elephant Whisperers* also touches on the unexpectedness of life itself, which leads to moments of both joy and sorrow through the course of 40 minutes of the film. Viewers can't help but smile as Bomman addresses Raghu like his child ("Who is the best elephant? Whose darling is this?"), or when Raghu, a fussy eater, throws tantrums, or when they see the rapport between Bomman and Bellie, who have devoted their lives to caring for the pachyderms.

It was a story worth pursuing for Gonsalves, who approached Netflix and producer Guneet Monga for funding after shooting a schedule and cutting a teaser for the film. "There are so many stories of animals being killed and species dying, and this was a positive story of man and animal working together," added Gonsalves. "I believe that coexistence is the way forward and that through mutual respect and cooperation, we can save the planet." Gonsalves has set up Earth Spectrum, under whose banner she wants to showcase stories that capture the "diversity of cultures and tribes across the world and the beauty of the natural world". She also wants to provide a platform to women and individuals and organisations engaged in the conservation of nature and biodiversity.

Gonsalves's passion for adventure, nature, environment and wildlife can be attributed to her family. Her father is a photographer, her mother is fond of animals, and her grandmother was an amateur naturalist who guided schoolchildren through nature reserves. Having spent her formative years in Ooty, family vacations in the Gonsalves household meant heading out into the wilderness to see animals and birds in their natural habitat. Gonsalves later completed her bachelor's degree in Science in Visual Communications at the GRD College of Science in Coimbatore, before studying at the Light and Life Academy in Ooty, one of India's premier photography institutes.

Gonsalves is also one of the four

Kartiki Gonsalves's docu-short is a moving tale about an old couple caring for an orphaned elephant

